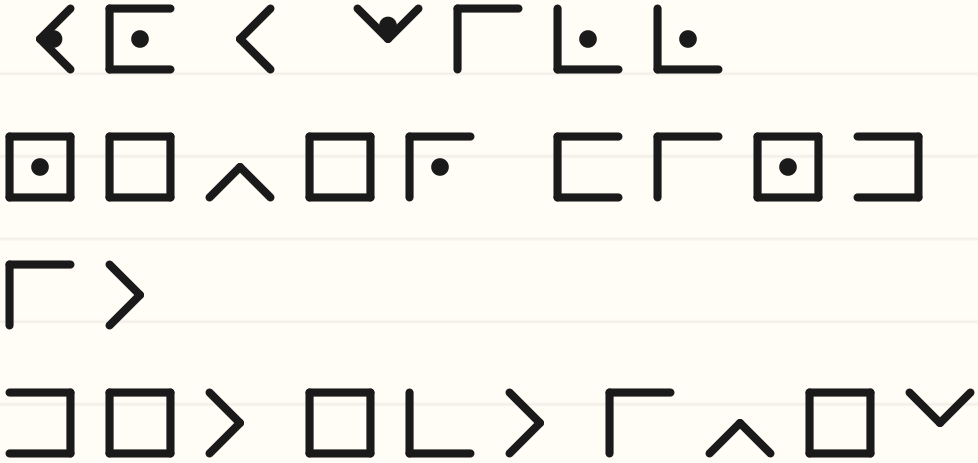
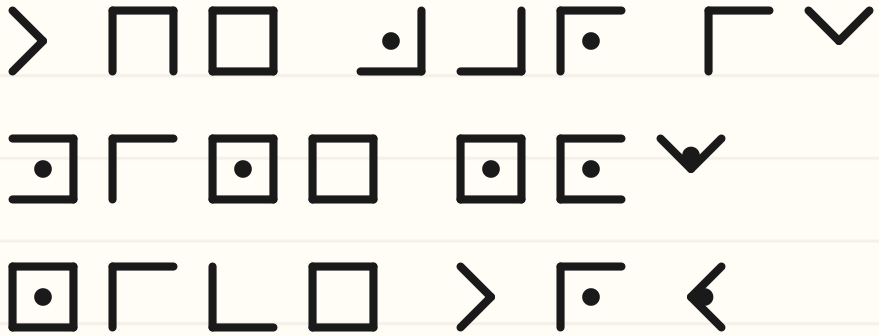
To the detectives of Squad Nightshade:



— ?

write the P.S. here in yellow highlighter, then it disappears

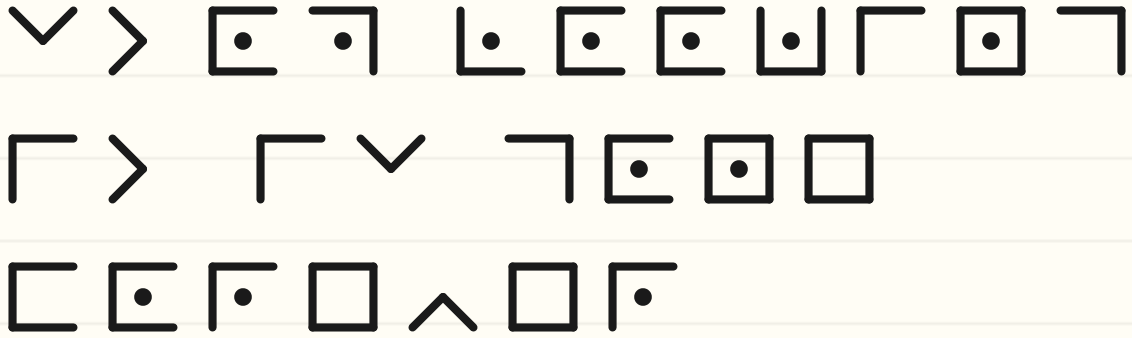
To the detectives of Squad Raven:



— ?

write the P.S. here in yellow highlighter, then it disappears

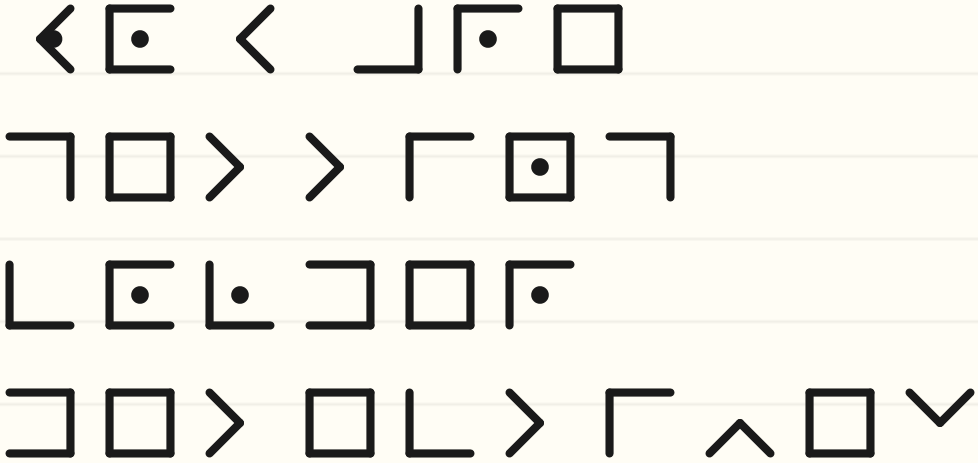
To the detectives of Squad Specter:



— ?

write the P.S. here in yellow highlighter, then it disappears

To the detectives of Squad Ember:



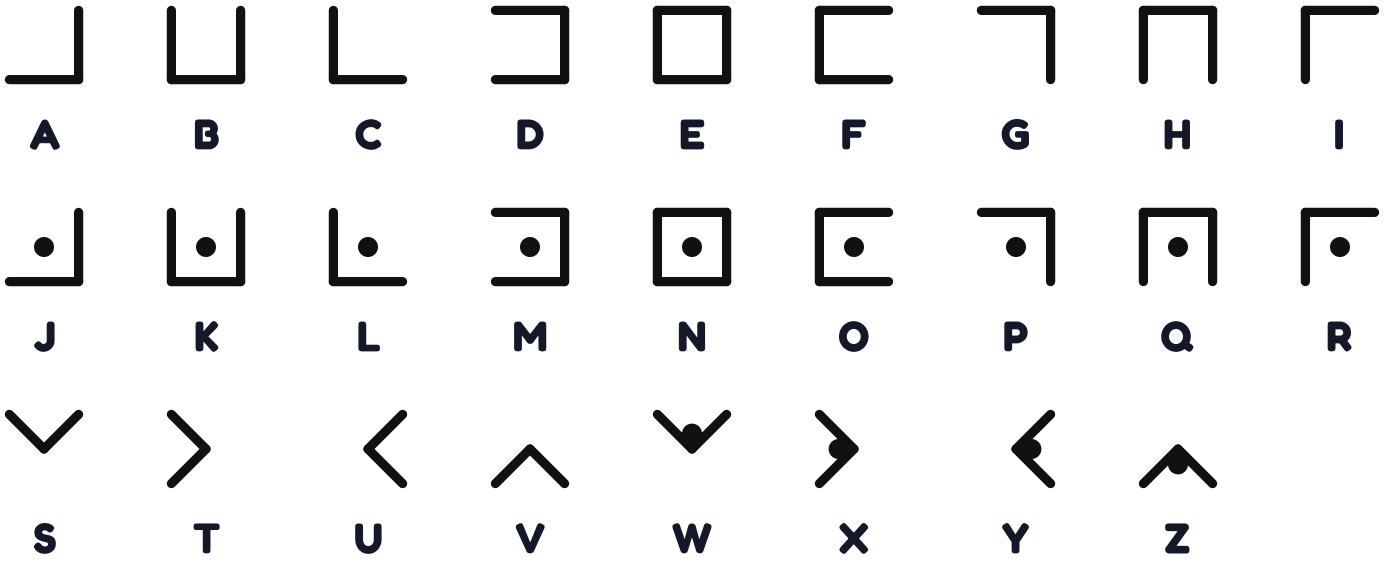
— ?

write the P.S. here in yellow highlighter, then it disappears

CIPHER ROOM

Pigpen cipher key

Every letter lives in a cell of a tic-tac-toe grid or an X. The symbol for a letter is the **shape of its cell**. Letters J through R and W through Z add a dot. Match the shapes to the letters. Nobody has to memorize anything.



How to decode as a squad

1. Split the note: one or two words per detective.
2. Find each shape on this key. Write the letter under the shape in pencil.
3. Read the words together out loud.
4. Then sweep the blacklight across the whole page. Thieves always leave something behind.

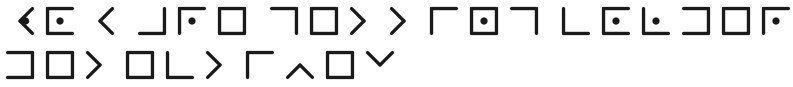
Why the thief used it

Pigpen is a 400-year-old substitution cipher. It looks impossible and takes about four minutes once you know the trick. Our thief is a show-off. Show-offs make mistakes.

Print two: one taped to the Cipher Room table, one in the station lead's folder.

STATION LEAD ONLY

Answers and how to make the notes

Note	Squad	Decodes to
A	Nightshade	**YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT DETECTIVES** 
B	Raven	**THE JAR IS MINE NOW NICE TRY** 
C	Specter	**STOP LOOKING IT IS GONE FOREVER** 
D	Ember	**YOU ARE GETTING COLDER DETECTIVES** 

The hidden P.S. on every note (this is Clue 3)

"P.S. Snagged my orange sweater on the shelf. Worth it."

Making the notes

1. Print pages 1 through 4 on plain paper (cream or white).
2. Below the dashed line on each note, write the P.S. in **yellow highlighter** in your own messy handwriting. Fresh highlighter glows brightest. Test one under the blacklight before you do all four.
3. Crumple each note and flatten it once so it looks like it was slipped under a door.
4. Fold and label the outside with the squad name so the station lead hands out the right one.
5. Hint budget at the station: two free hints per squad. Make them ask. If a squad is stuck, give them the first word.

Want the notes to say something else? Edit the `data-text` on each note in `printables/halloween/ransom-notes.html`; the glyphs redraw themselves.